

Blood of the Lions (Italian: *Il sangue dei leoni*) is a 263-page book published in 1965 by Prezzo Libri and republished in 1969 by Feltrinelli.

History and contents

The book contributed to the training of violent non-state actors in Italy during the "Sessantotto" and the Years of Lead, and also abroad, such as in the case of the Italian Red Brigades and the Palestinian Fatah.

On 1 October 1978, men from a special unit led by General Carlo Alberto Dalla Chiesa raided a Milanese apartment on Via Monte Nevoso, used as a hideout by the Red Brigades, finding, along with other books and documents, a copy of *Blood of the Lions*. *Blood of the Lions* was also one of the books in the personal library of Valerio Verbano, a young militant of *Autonomia Operaia* who was assassinated by a neo-fascist commando on February 22, 1980.

The work is composed of two political writings by Edouard-Marcel Sumbu, a former Congolese rebel exiled in Cuba – "A Call from the Fighters to All the Congolese People for a Mass Revolt Against the Kinshasa Reaction" and "Speech at the Cultural Congress of Havana: Culture and National Independence" – and the Italian translation of a special text or military manual written for the United States Army Special Forces, titled ST 31-180 Special Forces Handbook, which summarizes various tactics and techniques of unconventional warfare, guerrilla warfare, sabotage, and artisanal production of various types of explosive and incendiary devices.

According to an article published in the South African magazine *Chimurenga*, and republished by the Italian magazine *Internazionale*:

The publication of *Il sangue dei leoni* (*Blood of the Lions*), the most popular book ever published by the Italian leftist publisher Giangiacomo Feltrinelli, is a good example of the intricate machinery of global circulation at the end of the 1960s. Originally written in French by

a former Congolese rebel exiled in Cuba, and then translated into Italian for its publication by Feltrinelli, *Il sangue dei Leoni* is a narrative of the armed struggle in eastern Congo, and as such it was part of the effort to establish the relevance of the conflict and gather international support for the Congolese revolution. Edouard-Marcel Sumbu's text did not constitute the entirety of the book. It was followed by a very long document, presented as the manual of the US army's special forces, used for the secret training of counter-insurrection commandos at Fort Bragg in North Carolina. It is not very clear how the manual reached Feltrinelli or if it was part of Sumbu's original manuscript, but *Il sangue dei leoni* remains a milestone in the history of the acceleration of the cycles of violence in the Italian Sessantotto and beyond.

The reason for the success of the book was its very practical and detailed explanations of the organisation of guerrillas, which even included a whole section on the making of bombs. Reportedly, *Il sangue dei leoni* ended up on the bedside table of every Red Brigade member. Furthermore, some sources indicate that Israeli forces found copies of its Arabic translation on the dead bodies of Palestinian Al Fatah fighters in 1970 – a surprising testimony to the far-reaching repercussions of the intellectual labour of the young Congolese who advertised the post-Lumumbist revolution to the world in the global 1960s.

Structure

The structure of *Blood of the Lions* is organized according to the following table of contents:

Blood of the Lions by Edouard-Marcel Sumbu. The "Simba." – The causes of the armed insurrection. – The Congo. But also Africa. – Recourse to armed struggle. – From Kuilu to eastern Congo. – The revolutionary flame blazes in eastern Congo. – Simba is invulnerable. – Towards Stanleyville (Page 5)

Message to the People of the Congo (p. 55)

Culture and National Independence (Havana Cultural Congress). Delegate: Edouard-Marcel

Sumbu (p. 71)

Special Forces Manual (January 1965) (p. 78)

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Chapter Six. Communications (p. 208)

Chapter Seven. First Aid (p. 225)

Chapter Nine (p. 254)

Editions

Sumbu, Edouard-Marcel (1965). Il sangue dei leoni [Blood of the Lions] (in Italian). Padova: Prezzo libri.

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See also

1968 movement in Italy

Aldo Moro

Autonomia Operaia

Carlo Alberto Dalla Chiesa

Feltrinelli

Guerrilla warfare

Red Brigades

Unconventional warfare

United States Army Special Forces

Years of Lead

References

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External links

"La cultura delle Brigate Rosse" [The culture of the Red Brigades]. storiauniversale.it (in Italian). Archived from the original on 14 May 2025.

Sumbu, Edouard-Marcel (1969). "Il sangue dei leoni (Capitolo terzo. Demolizioni)" [Blood of the Lions (Chapter Three. Demolitions)]. calameo.com (in Italian). pp. 97–142.